

CALL FOR PROPOSALS

Innovation Fund for Citizen Participation in Electoral Processes in Africa



Election Civic Tech Fund

June 2025

Terms of reference

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I. INTRODUCTION – GENERAL CONTEXT

In many African countries, electoral processes remain vulnerable to disinformation, electoral violence, the exclusion of youth and women, and a lack of transparency. Civic technologies are emerging as powerful tools to strengthen participation, integrity and transparency in elections.

In this context, AfricTivistes, a pan-African network of cybercitizens for democracy, proposes an innovative support mechanism: the **Innovation Fund for Citizen Participation in Electoral Processes in Africa – Election Civic Tech Fund**. This fund is intended to support young Africans in the design, implementation and deployment of digital solutions tailored to the electoral challenges of their contexts.

The Fund is implemented as part of the **Digitalise Youth** and **AHEAD Africa** projects in which AfricTivistes is involved. [Digitalise Youth](#) seeks to strengthen democracy, participation and the influence of youth in democratic processes through digital tools in fourteen (14) target countries. [AHEAD Africa](#) aims to improve transparency, integrity and citizen participation in electoral processes through strategic and technical support to African civil society.

General context

Since 2015, AfricTivistes has established itself as a leading pan-African actor in promoting democracy, good governance, transparency and the rule of law through the strategic use of digital technologies. The network has supported

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more than one hundred civic initiatives, ranging from local governance to enhanced citizenship, digital rights and civic engagement.

Between 2020 and 2024, studies conducted by AfricTivistes - notably the [AfricTivistes Youth Initiatives Mapping](#) (AYIM, 2021) and the [Soobu Tech4Elections mapping](#) (2024) - revealed a significant lack of structural, financial and technical support for civic initiatives. The majority of these initiatives are self-funded, led by highly committed youth who are under-resourced and lack adequate support (see: [Concept Note – Election Civic Tech Fund](#)).

In a context where over 50% of elections in sub-Saharan Africa are affected by violence, authoritarian tendencies or transparency deficits, the use of civic technologies (civic tech) appears as an essential lever to restore citizens' trust in democratic institutions and electoral processes.

It is within this framework that AfricTivistes is launching the **Election Civic Tech Fund**, an innovative support mechanism designed to assist digital civic initiatives that strengthen inclusive electoral participation, transparency and the integrity of elections in fourteen (14) target countries:

- Cameroun,
- Benin,
- Burkina Faso,
- Ethiopia,
- Guinea,
- Mauritania,

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- Mali,
- Niger,
- Chad,
- Senegal,
- Somalia,
- Sudan,
- South Sudan,
- Togo.

These fourteen countries present varied political contexts, yet all face structural challenges **in terms of democracy, governance and electoral transparency**. Some are experiencing **transitions or prolonged crises where electoral institutions are often fragile or non-existent**. Others have recently been **shaken by coups d'état, putting the constitutional order** at risk and highlighting the important role of civil society in the return to democratic legitimacy. Some countries, though relatively stable, are witnessing a worrying **shrinking of civic space, limiting citizens' ability** to express themselves or organise freely. Finally, a number of States long considered models of democratic stability are facing growing **political tensions and attempts at democratic backsliding**.

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II. OBJECTIVES, TARGETS, PRIORITY AREAS AND EXPECTED RESULTS

II.1. General objective

Support, encourage and promote innovative initiatives that strengthen citizen participation, transparency and the integrity of electoral processes in Africa.

II.2. Specific objectives

- Encourage the emergence of civic tech
- Strengthen youth and women's participation through technology
- Support the creation of new communities of actors committed to electoral transparency

II.3. Target audience

The Fund is aimed at **young people aged 18 to 35**, who are nationals and/or residents of the 14 target countries: **Somalia, Ethiopia, Sudan, South Sudan, Senegal, Benin, Burkina Faso, Guinea, Chad, Cameroon, Mauritania, Niger, Mali, Togo.**

These countries are covered by the AHEAD Africa project and also constitute priority intervention areas of the **Digitalise Youth** initiative. Their selection is based on an in-depth analysis of their political and democratic contexts (see Section I: General context).

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II.4. Priority areas and Expected results

The priority areas of the Innovation Fund for Citizen Participation in Electoral Processes in Africa are:

- **II.4.1 : D.1 - Electoral civic technologies**

Objective D1 : Promote electoral civic technologies

This area supports the creation, deployment or improvement of technological solutions aimed at strengthening transparency, integrity and credibility in electoral processes, through the development of open-source tools, the integration of artificial intelligence, blockchain, or secure mobile applications for citizen participation.

Specific objectives D1 :

- Promote the use of innovative technologies in support of electoral transparency
- Support the development of local civic tech solutions tailored to national electoral contexts
- Promote open source and interoperability among citizen tools

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Example projects under D1 :

- Citizen electoral observation platforms
- Electoral monitoring systems using artificial intelligence
- Data visualisation tools for elections (mapping, data journalism)
- Use of blockchain for result tracking and traceability
- Development of chatbots or mobile apps for electoral education

Expected results D1:

- One or more inclusive mobile applications are developed and tested with target communities to improve access to electoral information and support citizen observation of elections
- Blockchain or artificial intelligence technologies are used to strengthen the security and integrity of electoral processes
- Data visualisation tools (such as maps or dashboards) are developed and made available online to enable citizens to follow real-time electoral trends, results or reported incidents
- Open-source code is developed, documented and shared to ensure the replicability of electoral civic tech solutions

• II.4.2 : D.2 - Citizen engagement, inclusion and electoral processes

Objective D2: Promote and strengthen the engagement and participation of youth and women in electoral processes through technology

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This area aims to increase citizen mobilisation, particularly among youth and women, in electoral monitoring, civic education and active participation in electoral processes, using digital technologies.

Specific objectives D2:

- Promote active participation of youth and women in elections
- Support a responsible and informed culture of civic and electoral awareness
- Encourage the creation of digital citizen communities

Example projects under D2:

- Design and deployment of databases of engaged citizen communities
- Educational and pedagogical projects on electoral rights and responsibilities
- Training programmes on civic engagement and digital citizenship
- Creation and strengthening of networks of young electoral observers
- Projects promoting the inclusion of women in electoral processes

Expected results D2:

- Digital civic and electoral education projects are planned and implemented
- Participatory citizen observation mechanisms are co-designed with youth and deployed
- Capacity-building tools in cybersecurity for electoral periods are designed and implemented

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- Series of inclusive educational modules or training kits are produced to help integrate youth and women into the electoral process
- Database of best practices in digital engagement is mapped, compiled and shared

• II.4.3 : D.3 - Media and electoral information

Objective D3: Contribute to ensuring reliable and accessible electoral information

This area aims to improve the quality, integrity, accessibility and reliability of electoral information by promoting fact-checking, countering disinformation - including foreign information manipulation and interference (FIMI) - and supporting independent media initiatives, particularly those led by youth or local communities.

Specific objectives D3:

- Support the emergence and structuring of independent, inclusive and accessible citizen media capable of covering electoral processes in local languages and in ways that reflect sociocultural realities (citizen journalism, data journalism, community media)
- Strengthen the capacity of media actors, young journalists and citizens to produce, verify and disseminate reliable electoral information
- Reduce the impact of electoral disinformation by developing innovative mechanisms to detect, analyse and respond to FIMI phenomena

Example projects under D3:

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- Community electoral fact-checking initiatives: websites or WhatsApp/AI bots to verify rumours and falsehoods circulating during the electoral campaign
- Digital initiatives to combat electoral disinformation (including FIMI)
- Capacity-building projects for young journalists and content creators on ethical electoral reporting and data journalism techniques
- Media and social monitoring mechanisms to track toxic electoral discourse, hate speech or manipulation on social media
- Creative and innovative media initiatives to simplify and explain the electoral process in national or local languages
- Cross-community projects between countries to develop joint responses to disinformation through shared approaches

Expected results D3:

- One or more collaborative, open-source electoral fact-checking initiatives are launched online
- Projects to combat electoral disinformation, including FIMI, are initiated
- Training programmes on journalistic techniques are deployed
- Methodological tools on innovation and impact journalism are published and shared

• II.4.4 : D.4 - Legal framework

Objective D4: Contribute to strengthening a more transparent electoral legal framework that better reflects citizens' aspirations

This area aims to improve the legal and institutional framework of elections through data-driven advocacy, citizen monitoring of electoral reforms, and

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collaborative mechanisms for tracking legal disputes and electoral institutes' commitments.

Specific objectives D4

- Contribute to improving the electoral regulatory framework
- Promote the implementation of recommendations arising from electoral processes
- Strengthen the role of civil society in its mission to observe and monitor the electoral process

Example projects under D4:

- Advocacy initiatives for inclusive and transparent electoral reforms
- Citizen monitoring initiatives on the implementation of electoral laws and standards
- Projects to track electoral litigation and produce accessible reports
- Mechanisms for research and development of legal databases or legal observatories

Expected results D4:

- Legal monitoring mechanisms on electoral reforms are documented and made publicly available
- Multi-stakeholder dialogue platforms (CSOs, legal professionals, institutions) are established to produce recommendations on electoral legislation
- Advocacy campaigns are conducted on key legal and electoral issues

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- Participatory tools for tracking electoral litigation are developed for CSOs and tested in real-life contexts

III. CALL FOR PROPOSALS TIMELINE

Milestone	Date
Launch of the call	10 June 2025
Application deadline	10 July 2025 at 23:59 GMT
Selection	11–17 July 2025

IV. FUNDING ARRANGEMENTS

The total amount of the Fund, **€175,000**, will be allocated across the different priority areas as follows:

- **40% (€70,000)** for Electoral Civic Technologies (D.1)
- **25% (€43,750)** for Citizen Engagement and Electoral Processes (D.2)
- **20% (€35,000)** for Media and Electoral Information (D.3)
- **15% (€26,250)** for the Legal Framework (D.4)

Between four (4) and six (6) major projects will be funded up to a maximum of €25,000 each, alongside micro-grants starting from €10,000.

A project may benefit from only one grant. While an initiative may address multiple priority areas, each applicant may submit only one proposal.

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Upon signing the grant agreement, the beneficiary will receive a first instalment of 40%. A second instalment of 50% will be released after submission of progress reports and proof that 70% of the initial funds have been used.

The remaining 10% will be disbursed following validation of final narrative and financial reports.

A grant agreement will be signed between AfricTivistes and the beneficiary organisation. The implementation and financial execution of the funded initiatives will be the sole responsibility of the beneficiaries.

The **project budget may include human resources costs**, capped at 15% of the total project budget, for implementation-related roles.

V. ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA

To be eligible for the **Election Civic Tech Fund**, applicants must:

- Submit a complete application file, including:
 - The official application form duly completed online via:
<https://electioncivictechfund.africtivistes.com/en>
 - A detailed provisional budget (ref: template provided)
 - A detailed project description (maximum 12 pages), including (ref: template provided):
 - A theory of change
 - An implementation plan (maximum 10 months)
 - The CVs of 2 to 3 key members of the initiative

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- Legal registration documents of the organisation or the lead entity in the case of a consortium
- Submit their application no later than **10 July 2025 at 23:59 (Dakar time / GMT)**, exclusively via the dedicated platform:
<https://electioncivictechfund.africivistes.com/en>
- Submit their project proposal in either **French or English**.

Initiatives led by women and meeting the criteria will be prioritised. Members of the Digitalise Youth and AHEAD Africa consortiums cannot be beneficiaries of the Fund. However, beneficiaries of [Digitalise Youth](#) or [AHEAD Africa](#) projects may apply for a grant.

To be eligible for the **Innovation Fund for Citizen Participation in Electoral Processes in Africa – Election Civic Tech Fund**, submitted initiatives and projects must meet the following conditions:

- **Legal status:** Be led by a legally registered entity in one of the 14 target countries (e.g. association, NGO, startup, registered collective, incubator, cooperative, etc.)
- **Thematic eligibility:** Propose a project that falls within at least one of the four intervention areas defined by the Fund (electoral technologies, citizen engagement, media/electoral information, legal framework)
- **Minimum experience:** Demonstrate experience in at least one of the targeted areas through previous projects, partnerships or on-the-ground activities

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- **Management capacity:** Demonstrate technical and administrative capacity to manage grants and produce complete narrative and financial reports
- **Youth and women:** Be led by **young people (aged 18–35)**; **priority will be given to projects led by women** or with a **documented impact on women's inclusion**
- **Openness and replicability:** Develop projects using an open-source logic (code or methodology that is accessible and reusable), or show potential for replication in other contexts
- **Use of digital technologies:** Propose initiatives that **incorporate digital technologies** in multiple components of their activities.

VI. APPLICATION SUBMISSION PROCEDURE

Before starting the online application process, project applicants are strongly encouraged to carefully prepare the following two documents using the templates provided in Annexes:

- A **detailed project description** (maximum 12 pages)
- A **detailed budget**

These documents will serve as the basis for completing the digital form on the dedicated platform: <https://electioncivictechfund.africivistes.com/en>

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Submissions must be completed **exclusively online** and follow **four structured steps**, each designed to provide a better understanding of your initiative and team:

Step 1: Your Democratic Vision

Approx. 15–20 minutes | 3 sections

Present the democratic vision driving your initiative. You will be asked to identify a specific electoral issue, explain why it is a priority, who it affects and select the priority area your project addresses. Use clear and accessible language.

Step 2: Technological Impact

Approx. 10–15 minutes | 3 sections

Choose up to three key technologies from six available options to support your project. Each choice contributes to an automatically generated impact score that reflects the technological and social potential of your solution. A visualisation of your technological profile will help assess the coherence of your strategy.

Step 3: Your Civic Team

Approx. 20–25 minutes | 3 sections

Assemble a team with complementary roles. Describe their experience, competencies (technical, social, field-based, management), and motivation. A visual radar of your team's skill set will guide you towards a balanced and effective project team.

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Step 4: Your Digital Arsenal

Approx. 30–45 minutes | 3 sections

Prepare and upload all required documents: legal registration, CVs, project description, budget, and others.

In addition to the step-by-step instructions available on the platform, recommended preparation guidelines are also provided. It is strongly advised to review them carefully **before completing the form**. You must reach a minimum **completion score of 80%** in order to submit your application.

VII. EVALUATION OF SUBMITTED PROJECTS

Submitted projects will be evaluated according to the following criteria:

1. Relevance and strategic alignment (25 points)

- Relevance of the project to the Fund's intervention areas
- Alignment with the Fund's objectives
- Responsiveness to the specific challenges of the target country or region

2. Innovation and added value (20 points)

- Innovative nature of the proposed civic tech solution
- Originality of the approach or tool developed
- Potential to enhance the impact of existing initiatives

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3. Technical and operational feasibility (20 points)

- Clarity of the methodology and theory of change
- Realism of the timeline and expected results
- Capacity of the team to implement the project (skills, experience, available resources)

4. Impact and sustainability (15 points)

- Potential impact on citizen participation, transparency or electoral integrity
- Strategy for sustainability or scale-up after the grant period
- Integration of open governance and inclusion principles (gender, youth, diversity)

5. Budget and resource efficiency (10 points)

- Consistency between the budget and planned activities
- Clear justification of costs
- Efficient use of resources to maximise impact

6. Monitoring, evaluation and learning (10 points)

- Presence of clear, measurable performance indicators
- A clear monitoring and evaluation plan
- Mechanisms planned for capturing and sharing lessons learned

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A multidisciplinary selection committee of **eight (8) members**, including representatives from the AHEAD Africa and Digitalise Youth consortiums, will be established to evaluate and select the beneficiary projects.

VIII. FUND IMPLEMENTATION AND MONITORING SCHEDULE

Phases	Month	Activities
Phase 1	June-August 2025	• Launch • Selection • Contracting • Initial training
Phase 2	Septembre 2025 – April 2026	• Implementation • Capacity building • Support
Phase 3	August-Septembre 2026	• Final evaluation, • Capitalisation
Phase 4	Octobre 2026	• Capitalisation

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		• White paper
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IX. PERSONAL DATA PROCESSING

Beneficiary initiatives under this call for proposals agree that AfricTivistes may collect and process information relating to them for the purpose of implementing this call and until its conclusion, including within digital databases. They waive any claims against AfricTivistes and its staff in this regard.

X. CONTACTS

For any questions, please write to info@afriktivistes.org by 9 July 2025.

XI. ANNEXES

- [Application project description template](#)
- [Budget template](#)
- Concept note – Election Civic Tech Fund
- Dedicated platform link: <https://electioncivictechfund.afriktivistes.com/en>

Any incomplete application or submission sent after 10 July 2025 at 23:59 GMT, or submitted by email, will be considered ineligible.

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